

When to use the Emergency Contraceptive Pill (ECP)

Within 72 hours of unprotected sex or forced sex. Works best if taken within 12 hours.

When not to use the ECP

- If pregnancy is already confirmed or suspected.
- This pill must not replace regular contraceptives. It is meant only for an emergency.
- Those with an allergy to Levonorgestrel should avoid it.

Advantages

- It is available over-the-counter; a doctor's prescription is not required to buy it.
- It is an inexpensive means to avoid conception after unprotected sex and helps reduce abortions.
- It can help rape victims avoid unwanted pregnancies.

Disadvantages

- Easy availability has also led to rampant misuse.
- Long-term usage has side effects. It is not recommended for minors.
- It does not offer protection against other sexually transmitted diseases.

cannot do. Just popping the pill won't help. And both men and women need to realise the consequences," says Bangalore-based sociologist Ramani Rajaratnam. Dr Rita Bali, head of obstetrics and gynaecology of Bali Clinics, says: "There are many problems but ECP's benefits outnumber its disadvantages. Young women should be advised against its indiscriminate use. The advertisers should stress the emergency nature of the i-pill," Bali says.

With a combined annual sale of 8.2 million tablets, the pharma companies are splurging on their advertising campaigns but not enough awareness is being created to prevent its misuse. Thanks to the campaign, people are now acquainted with the fact that it provides freedom against unwanted pregnancies, but there's no stress on the word emergency. Cipla's i-pill is the largest selling brand in India while other brands include Unwanted-72 from Mankind Pharma, EC2 by Zydus, Norlevo from Win Medicare and E-Pill by Panchsheel Organics.

The majority of the medical community has endorsed this form of emergency contraceptive as an OTC though some doctors feel it might be better regulated as a prescription drug. It is a move fraught with problems because in India even prescription drugs and drugs under Schedule H are easily available over-the-counter. "Making it a prescription drug will only increase fraud, time delays and definitely increase abortions in the country," says Hyderabad-based Dr Rakesh Malhotra, who has endorsed the ECP as a safe option provided the pharma companies are able to create awareness to prevent its misuse. Gynaecologist Balakrishna Badigar says, "People need to understand that an i-pill cannot replace regular contraceptives. Also, it is to be used only in an emergency and cannot protect one from AIDS or other sexually transmitted diseases."

There is an urgent need for publicising the dos and don'ts about such pills, their side effects and possibly even a statutory warning. It could save a lot of concern and complications that usually happen, well, the morning after. ■

It's easily available, inexpensive and well advertised. And that's where the trouble with the new emergency contraceptive pill starts.

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changing the OTC nature of the drug, saying it would defeat its purpose. Elsewhere, in Russia, the UK, the US, Canada and many Asian countries, these pills are available OTC. It is banned in the Middle East and parts of South America on religious grounds.

The controversy over the ECP, however, is unlikely to die down. While most doctors agree that the ECP is a safe option even for long-term use, there is little research on its misuse. Even though the pharmaceutical companies manufacturing these pills stress the word emergency, many doctors say that young women, even married women, use them as regular contraceptive pills.

"I haven't really read up on the dos and don'ts of the drug. I have used them more than a couple of times a month," says advertising copywriter Ragini Ravichander from Bangalore. Literature provided by the pharmaceutical companies insists that the ECP must not be used more than once in a cycle, but then not too many people seem to be reading the fine print. Nausea or some bleeding are said to be among common short-term side effects. "The problem is not with the i-pill or any of the other ECPs in the market; the problem is with the awareness. These pills should be sold with statutory warnings about what the i-pill can do as well as what it